

The Mapmaker's Moth

Licensed classic · labyrinth edition

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Girl Who Drew Better Than She Spoke

In the seventh aisle of the Library Labyrinth, where atlases slept spine to spine like dozing whales, lived a girl named Lina Quill. She was eleven and could draw a harbor from memory after seeing it once, right down to the cracked third plank on the eastern dock.

Grown-ups called her gifted. Lina preferred accurate.

She lived above her grandmother's map stall, The Folded Horizon, where paper smelled of rain and ink and old promises. While other children played chase through ladderways, Lina traced coastlines with a sharpened cedar pencil and measured distance with a strip of ribbon knotted in thumb-widths.

The Labyrinth changed, as all proper labyrinths do. Staircases argued with gravity. Corridors shifted when nobody watched. But maps still mattered. A good map did not freeze a place. It taught you how a place liked to move.

On the first fog-night of Lantern Month, Lina stayed late in the cartography room after her grandmother had gone home. She was copying a rescue route for shelf-villages that flooded in heavy weather. Her hand was steady. Her lettering was neat. Her compass point glowed faintly in the blue light.

Then a moth landed on the map.

It was larger than any moth Lina had seen, wings pale as moonmilk, veins lit from within like tiny rivers of gold. The light did not flicker like fire. It pulsed like breathing.

"Shoo," Lina whispered, waving gently. She never swatted. Paper tore too easily when people moved carelessly.

The moth ignored her. It lowered its head to the page and took a bite.

Not of paper. Of line.

The black route-line between Ash Stair and Cinder Nook vanished where the moth touched it, as cleanly as if erased by invisible fingers.

Lina froze. The moth chewed once more, and a second line disappeared: a shortcut she had copied from an older survey.

Then it lifted, circled her twice, and settled on the lamp hook above her desk.

Lina checked the source map in the archive drawer. The shortcut line was not on it.

Someone, sometime, had added a false route to the copy she had used.

The moth had eaten only the lie.

Chapter 2 — Ink Teeth and Quiet Warnings

By breakfast, Lina had tested the impossible three times.

She drew one true line and one invented line across a scrap sheet. The luminous moth watched from the rim of her teacup, antennae tilted like question marks. When Lina laid down the page, the moth stepped to the fake line and nibbled it away, leaving the true line untouched.

She tried again with symbols. False bridge marker? Gone. Imaginary stairwell? Gone. Real well-house seal? Left pristine.

Lina's grandmother, Nani Rukhsana, listened without interrupting. She did not laugh. She did not say impossible. She asked, as wise people do, the useful question.

"Who benefits from wrong maps?"

Lina thought of late couriers, missed medicine deliveries, rescue teams arriving where doors did not exist. Wrong maps wasted time. In emergencies, wasted time could hurt people.

"Someone who wants confusion," Lina said.

Nani nodded and tied her silver hair into a practical knot. "Then we do not announce a truth-eating moth to the whole market. We investigate quietly."

They named the moth Morrow, because it had arrived with morning and seemed to point toward what came next. Morrow approved by climbing onto Lina's sleeve and glowing brighter.

That afternoon Lina carried maps to the Surveyors' Hall for routine stamping. She watched clerks closely. Most worked honestly, heads bent over vellum and seal-wax. But one senior drafter, Master Pell, paused too long over a freight route, then slipped a correction sheet beneath his ledger before anyone could see.

Morrow, hidden in Lina's satchel, began to glow warm through canvas.

At closing bell, Lina copied the day's route ledger from memory. She had done this since age nine, turning memory into practice the way musicians turned scales into songs. Three entries did not match old grid references. Tiny changes, easy to miss. A lane shifted twenty paces east. A culvert marked where there was only wall.

Misdirections, not disasters.

Small lies trained people to doubt their own eyes. Big lies could come later.

When she returned upstairs, Nani had laid out an old brass tube from the back shelf, etched with a moth and a compass rose.

"Your great-grandmother called this a verifier's scope," Nani said. "She said it belonged to the licensed classics edition keepers, back when maps were checked against story-truth, not only measurements."

Lina lifted the scope. The glass was clouded with age, but when she peered through it at her route copy, faint red threads appeared where lines had been tampered.

Morrow tapped the tube with one tiny foot, as if to say: yes. That.

Chapter 3 — The Hall of Official Certainty

The Surveyors' Hall loved certainty the way bakers loved ovens.

Everything there was squared, labeled, and stamped. Rulers hung in parallel. Ink wells sat in exact rows. Even the apprentices whispered in straight lines.

Lina entered with Nani and a satchel of questionable maps. Morrow hid beneath Lina's collar, warm as a heartbeat against her neck.

At the central desk sat Chief Surveyor Dareth, a man whose beard was trimmed with geometric precision and whose favorite word was protocol.

"A complaint?" he asked, without looking up.

"A concern," Nani said pleasantly. "About route integrity."

Dareth finally looked up. His expression shifted when he saw Lina. Children did not often bring evidence to his desk, and when they did, adults usually translated for them.

Lina laid down two maps: one archive original, one field copy. Same title. Different path lines.

"This copy was altered after certification," she said.

"Then your copyist blundered," Dareth replied.

Lina uncapped her ink bottle and drew a tiny made-up alley off the freight route. She opened her collar enough for Morrow to step onto the page.

The room went silent.

Morrow ate the invented alley in one neat bite.

Lina passed the verifier's scope to Dareth. Through the clouded lens, tampered segments lit red like thread pulled loose from fabric.

For a moment, something like worry crossed his face. Then his official expression returned.

"Interesting trick," he said. "Not admissible."

"Not admissible?" Nani repeated. Her tone stayed mild, which was when people should have worried most.

"Anecdotal, unregulated, biologically unverified. We cannot rewrite Hall records on the testimony of... a moth."

Lina felt heat rise in her chest. "People follow these maps. If they're wrong, people can get hurt."

Dareth folded his hands. "If there is misconduct, internal review will handle it."

Internal review meant slow. Slow meant more false lines spreading.

As they turned to leave, Lina saw Master Pell at a side table. He pretended to sort seals while watching her through lowered lashes.

Morrow stiffened on Lina's shoulder, light pulsing quick-quick-quick.

Outside in the lane, Nani exhaled. "We won't win this through their process."

"Then what do we do?"

Nani pointed toward the oldest stacks, where licensed classics volumes were kept in climate-charmed cases and stories sometimes advised the present.

"We ask the Labyrinth for precedent," she said. "If the Hall won't hear a moth, maybe they'll hear history."

That evening, under green-shaded lamps, Lina found a brittle record in a folio labeled Cartographic Incidents, Year 143.

One line had been underlined by an earlier hand:

When official maps diverged from lived truth, the Moth of Morrowing consumed false marks and named a child-verifier.

Chapter 4 — The Forgotten Verifier's Oath

The record led Lina and Nani to a locked balcony above the Map Rotunda, reachable only by a spiral stair hidden behind an atlas shelf. The key came from Archivist Behnam, who pretended sternness but slipped Lina a fig biscuit "for intellectual stamina."

On the balcony stood twelve stone tablets, each engraved with an oath from a different guild year. Dust lay thick on the newest. The oldest tablet gleamed where fingers had traced it recently, though no one admitted coming here.

Lina read aloud:

I map not to command the world but to meet it honestly. I mark uncertainty where uncertainty lives. I correct error

before pride. I refuse the comfort of useful lies.

Morrow fluttered to the tablet and rested above the words refuse useful lies. Its wings brightened until the letters shone.

"Child-verifier," Nani murmured. "They used to appoint one during disputed years. Someone with fresh eyes and no title to protect."

"What happened to the role?"

"Roles that question power tend to vanish politely."

They copied the oath and carried it to three people they trusted: Postkeeper Alma, Bridgewright Jun, and Teacher Sadiq. All three had practical reasons to care about accurate routes.

By dusk they had stories. Jun had repaired a bridge that maps claimed was stone; it was rope and nearly failed under cargo. Alma had rerouted medicine due to a lane marked open but sealed months ago. Sadiq had led students into a dead corridor because a field map showed a mural there that had been moved years prior.

Separate mistakes could be chance. A pattern of small wrongness was intent.

That night Lina spread twenty-two map copies across her floor and let Morrow inspect each. The moth ate thirty-one false marks, never touching a true one. Lina tracked every deletion on transparent overlays.

The tampering clustered around supply routes and civic access points: wells, clinics, council halls, postal branches.

Confusion where coordination mattered most.

Near midnight, Lina discovered a hidden mark in Master Pell's pen style: a tiny hooked serif on every altered numeral seven.

Not proof by itself. But a signature of habit.

Nani brewed cardamom tea and looked at the overlays for a long while.

"This is bigger than one drafter," she said at last. "Too widespread. Someone has tolerated this."

"Chief Dareth?"

"Perhaps. Perhaps someone above him. We still need undeniable evidence."

Morrow flew to Lina's blank notebook, tapped it twice, then landed on her compass.

Lina understood. Maps could be forged on paper. Harder to forge in place.

"Field verification," she said.

At dawn, she, Nani, and Morrow would walk the disputed routes with witness notes, distance ribbons, and the verifier's scope.

If lies had been drawn, the city itself would testify.

Chapter 5 — The Route That Wasn't There

The first disputed route crossed South Lantern Quarter, where laundry lines crisscrossed alley roofs like festival bunting and bakers shouted prices before sunrise.

Map copy: emergency lane from Well Court to Candle Clinic, six-minute access.

Reality: brick wall, iron-locked, no lane at all.

Lina marked the discrepancy with measured steps, sketch notes, and witness signatures from two residents and a bread seller who insisted on adding a doodle of his cat beside his name.

Second route, Harbor Spiral.

Map copy: service stair to floodgate crankhouse.

Reality: stair ended at sealed archive door. The floodgate crankhouse lay one level lower via a narrow side run not shown.

Third route, Ember Ferry shelves.

Map copy: weighted bridge rated for cargo.

Reality: bridge removed after rot, replaced by foot-plank with child-width railing.

By noon Lina's evidence folio had grown heavy.

Then came the dangerous one.

Map copy: evacuation corridor through Glassbind Stack, clear and lit.

Reality: corridor collapsed last winter and was officially marked hazardous.

If a fire alarm sent families that way, they could be trapped.

Lina stood before the blocked entrance, dust glittering in sunbeams through cracked panes, and felt her stomach drop.

"This isn't carelessness," she whispered.

Nani's face had gone very still. "No. This is sabotage by paperwork."

As they turned to leave, two Hall wardens stepped from the stairwell.

"Lina Quill?" one asked.

"Yes?"

"By order of Chief Surveyor Dareth, all unsanctioned map audits are prohibited. Hand over your folio."

Nani stepped forward. "On what authority?"

The warden held up a writ with bright red seal wax.

Lina read the wording. Emergency preservation order. It sounded official and reasonable until she reached the signature line.

Master Pell.

Not Dareth.

The wardens reached for the folio.

Morrow shot from Lina's shoulder in a burst of light, circling the writ. It bit the seal itself.

The red wax darkened, then flaked away, revealing another stamp beneath: temporary draft order, not enforceable until ratified.

Fake urgency stamped over unratified authority.

The wardens stared. One muttered, "That's not proper issue format."

Nani smiled without warmth. "Indeed."

They walked away quickly, eager to be elsewhere.

Lina clutched the folio tighter. The map tampering was one layer. Paper orders had been altered too.

When systems became confusing enough, ordinary people stopped challenging them.

At twilight Lina and Nani reached home to find a message pinned to their door:

Stop digging. Not all wrong lines are accidental.

No signature. Hooked serif on the seven in stop at 7th bell handwritten below.

Morrow settled beside the note and ate only one word.

accidental.

Chapter 6 — Trial by Compass

News of the tampered writ spread faster than Council notices. By next morning, market vendors were comparing route errors over oranges and lamp oil. Parents asked teachers for alternate evacuation paths. Postkeepers demanded corrected freight diagrams.

Chief Surveyor Dareth announced a public review "to restore confidence."

Lina knew a containment performance when she heard one.

The review convened in the Rotunda, beneath a painted ceiling of constellations used for old navigation lessons. Councillors sat on the high dais. Guild officials occupied front benches. Ordinary residents lined the aisles, standing shoulder to shoulder.

Dareth opened with polished phrases about institutional integrity.

Then he called Master Pell as key witness for "internal correction efforts."

Pell bowed modestly and began blaming apprentices, weather distortion, and "juvenile misunderstanding of drafting complexity."

Lina felt anger spark, but Nani squeezed her wrist once: wait.

When public testimony opened, Lina walked to the central table with her folio, overlays, witness sheets, and the verifier's scope.

"Permission to demonstrate?" she asked Councilor Yara, who chaired civic safety.

Yara looked to Dareth. Dareth looked unhappy. The hall looked expectant.

"Granted," Yara said.

Lina laid out three map pairs and field notes. She kept her voice calm, as Nani had taught her when facts were stronger than volume.

"These are measured discrepancies with witnesses and date marks. Here are copied numerals from altered entries. Same hooked seven across twenty-nine records."

Pell scoffed. "Common handwriting trait."

Lina held up a Hall supply request signed by Pell that morning. Hooked seven, identical pressure break.

Murmurs rose.

Pell's jaw tightened. "Even if there were errors, they were corrected."

Lina nodded toward Morrow, perched on the table edge.

"Then this should do nothing."

She drew a fresh line exactly where Pell's emergency lane allegedly ran through Glassbind Stack. Morrow ate it instantly.

Gasps. Someone clapped once before catching themselves.

Pell lunged for the map, knocking over an ink well. Black ink spread across the table like nightwater.

Morrow darted through the spill, touching hidden notations written in dissolving ink. Under the verifier's scope, ghost marks flared red: reroute wells, delay post, isolate clinics.

Not random. Strategic choke points.

Councilor Yara stood. "Master Pell, explain these marks."

Pell's composure cracked. "You don't understand. Too many independent routes make governance impossible. Confusion creates compliance. We needed centralized control."

The hall went very quiet.

Lina heard a child in the back whisper, "He made people get lost on purpose."

Dareth rose halfway, then sat again, as if discovering no speech would save him.

Council guards stepped forward.

Before Pell was escorted away, he looked directly at Lina.

"Maps are power," he said bitterly.

Lina met his stare. "No. Maps are trust."

Morrow glowed so bright the red ghost-marks burned away.

Chapter 7 — The Missing District

Pell's arrest should have ended the matter. It did not.

As clerks reviewed altered ledgers, Lina discovered references to a district she had never seen on current maps: Starwell Annex. Old freight records listed deliveries there. School rosters mentioned students from there. But modern city charts showed only "unassigned maintenance stacks."

An entire neighborhood had been erased gradually, first from route copies, then from official indexes.

"Why erase a district?" Lina asked.

Archivist Behnam rubbed his forehead. "If services stop appearing on maps, budgets stop reaching them. If names vanish from charts, people become easy to ignore."

Nani unfolded a year-old ledger page. "Look: water allotment reduced after annex designation changed."

Paper could disappear people without moving a single brick.

Lina insisted on visiting.

With Alma the postkeeper and Jun the bridgwright as witnesses, she followed old grid coordinates through maintenance corridors and unlabeled turns until they reached a rusted gate painted with stars faded nearly to gray.

Beyond it lay a narrow district tucked between major stacks: forty homes, a tiny clinic, two communal ovens, and a square where children played kick-ball with a stitched cloth bundle.

Residents stared at the visitors with practiced caution.

An elder woman approached, cane tapping.

"You're from Hall?" she asked.

"No," Lina said quickly. "I'm a mapmaker's apprentice. We're here to verify routes."

The elder snorted softly. "We filed corrections for years. No one answered. Post stopped coming direct. We collect from side depots now."

Alma looked stricken. "I never saw those requests."

The elder's name was Mariam Vale, once a navigation tutor. She led Lina through lanes omitted from current maps: shortcut to clinic, rain-shelter corridor, safe staircase with double rail for elders.

Essential paths invisible on official charts.

Morrow flew ahead, pausing at each omitted marker. It did not eat anything now. It simply glowed, as if illuminating absences.

In the square center stood a broken signboard. Faint lettering remained:

STARWELL ANNEX COMMUNITY MAP — LAST UPDATED 12 YEARS AGO

Lina felt a new kind of anger, colder and cleaner than rage.

"We'll put you back on the map," she said.

Mariam studied her face, measuring sincerity.

"Child," she said, "we were always here. Put the map back on us."

That evening Lina drafted the first updated Starwell sheet with residents gathered around, correcting every lane and name and shared resource.

Children argued joyfully over whether the fig tree stair counted as a landmark. Mariam settled it by declaring all useful trees were landmarks.

When Lina finished, Morrow landed on the title line and traced it with light:

Starwell Annex, verified by residents.

Chapter 8 — The Storm Atlas

Three days into citywide corrections, storm sirens rang.

A hard rain front slammed the upper stacks, and runoff channels overflowed into lower lanes. Flood protocols activated. Couriers sprinted. Bell-ropes shook. People grabbed go-bags and followed evacuation maps posted at stairheads.

Newly corrected maps had not yet replaced every old copy.

Lina stood in the Rotunda with wet hair and pounding heart as teams sorted route packets for district wardens.

"We need one definitive storm atlas," Councilor Yara said. "Now."

Too much for one person. Unless one person knew exactly how to organize many.

Lina climbed onto the central table.

"Cartographers to me! Apprentices, teachers, postkeepers, residents from every district. We divide by grid and verify in pairs. No line without witness."

No one questioned her. Crisis had a way of revealing who could coordinate.

Morrow flew circuit after circuit above the room, lighting workstations like moving moonfire. When a false mark appeared, it vanished with one bite. When a debated line needed field confirmation, Lina marked it amber: uncertain, verify.

Hours blurred.

Jun returned soaked from bridge checks with updated load limits. Alma delivered live courier reports on passable lanes. Mariam arrived from Starwell with two teens carrying hand-drawn overlays and a box of sharpened pencils "because panic dulls points."

By midnight they had a storm atlas: routes for families, medics, and supply teams, each line color-coded by urgency and accessibility.

Lina refused to print "safe" where conditions could change. She labeled segments probable, monitored, or avoid. Honesty over comfort.

Council runners spread copies while rain hammered skylights.

At second bell, a report came in: Candle Clinic evacuated twenty-two patients through an alternate stair Lina had added from resident testimony. At third bell: floodgate crankhouse reached in time via corrected Harbor Spiral run. At fourth: Starwell's elder shelter supplied through restored lane.

The atlas was working.

Near dawn, Lina staggered against a shelf, hands cramped, eyes burning. Nani wrapped a blanket around her shoulders and pressed sweet tea into her hands.

"Look," Nani whispered.

Through Rotunda windows, wardens were replacing old route placards with new storm pages, one district at a time.

Morrow landed on Lina's wrist, wings dim with tired light.

"You did well," Nani said.

Lina shook her head. "We did."

Outside, rain eased from roar to steady drumming.

Inside, people moved with purpose instead of panic, following lines that respected reality.

In the Labyrinth, that counted as grace.

Chapter 9 — The Archive Beneath the Archive

After the storm, investigations widened. Pell had altered records, yes. But some erasures predated him. Someone had built a system where oversight was optional and corrections could disappear quietly.

Lina wanted to understand the root, not only prune branches.

Archivist Behnam finally confessed there was a sub-archive beneath the Hall, used in older years for disputed drafts and political correspondence.

"No official key survives," he said.

Nani produced a bent brass key from her sewing tin.

"Official keys rarely survive in official drawers," she said.

The sub-archive was reached through a hatch hidden behind rolled nautical charts. Air smelled of cedar rot and iron dust. Shelves held boxed files tied in black ribbon, labels faded but legible enough: route appeals, suppression notices, budget reallocations.

Lina found a folder stamped CONFIDENTIAL RATIONALIZATION.

Inside were memos arguing that "peripheral districts with low guild representation" could have services consolidated by "cartographic simplification." In plain language: erase minor lanes, merge names, reduce obligations.

A policy of convenience disguised as efficiency.

Signed not by Pell, but by former Chief Surveyor Merek twenty years earlier, with endorsements from two council offices now long vacated.

Morrow hovered over the page and did not bite. The lines were true records, however ugly.

"Truth can still be harmful," Lina murmured.

"Yes," Nani said. "But if hidden, harm repeats."

They copied every memo and surfaced to daylight.

Councilor Yara called an open hearing and published the documents in full, including names, dates, and impacts. There was shouting. There were apologies, some sincere, some strategic. There were demands for restitution and oversight.

Lina proposed three reforms: resident co-sign required for district maps, public correction log visible in every ward, and annual child-verifier appointment with independent authority to challenge official drafts.

The chamber buzzed at the boldness of an eleven-year-old dictating structural policy.

Mariam from Starwell rose with her cane and said, "Adopt all three."

So did Alma, Jun, Teacher Sadiq, and eventually enough voices that resistance became awkward.

The vote passed by wide margin.

When the session ended, Dareth approached Lina privately. He looked older, shoulders lowered as if certainty had leaked out.

"I should have listened sooner," he said.

Lina studied him, then nodded once. "Then listen now. Trust is slower to rebuild than to break."

He bowed his head. "Understood."

Morrow settled on the edge of Dareth's sleeve for one second, then returned to Lina.

Not forgiveness.

A beginning.

Chapter 10 — The Map of Promises

Restoring routes was one task. Restoring confidence was another.

Lina decided the city needed a map that did more than show paths. It needed commitments people could measure.

She called it the Map of Promises.

At the center of the Rotunda she hung a giant blank sheet, taller than two adults, gridded but mostly open. Around it she placed bowls of colored pins.

Blue pins: services restored. Green pins: routes verified with residents. Gold pins: pending corrections with dates. Red threads: unresolved harms requiring action.

"No hidden ledgers," Lina announced at the launch gathering. "If a line changes, everyone sees it."

Children loved placing pins. Adults loved, reluctantly, being accountable where children could ask sharp questions.

Starwell received direct postal routing by week two. Gold turned blue.

South Lantern gained a reopened well-court lane with accessibility rail. Green to blue.

Three districts still carried red threads where compensation and staffing had lagged. Lina refused to remove red

until commitments were met.

"It's discouraging," one official complained.

"It's honest," Lina replied.

Morrow perched at the map's top edge like a living legend marker.

The moth's role changed as systems improved. It bit fewer lies because fewer were drawn. Sometimes it simply walked a line and left a dusting of light where trust had been kept.

During the second month, Lina received a package wrapped in archival cloth. Inside lay a child-sized surveyor's badge engraved INDEPENDENT VERIFIER, and a short letter from the newly formed Civic Cartography Board.

Appointment confirmed, pending annual renewal by public vote.

Lina pinned the badge beside her desk, not on her jacket.

"Why not wear it?" asked Teacher Sadiq when he visited.

"Badges are useful reminders," Lina said. "But maps should convince by clarity, not by metal."

That evening she sat with Nani on the rooftop above The Folded Horizon, watching lanterns kindle across corrected routes. The city looked less like a puzzle and more like a woven cloth repaired carefully where it had torn.

"Do you think we're done?" Lina asked.

Nani laughed softly. "Maps are verbs, Lina."

"Verbs?"

"They keep happening."

Morrow circled them once, then glided toward the Rotunda where the Map of Promises glowed under night lamps.

Lina opened her notebook and wrote:

Accuracy is not the opposite of kindness. It is one form of kindness, especially in emergencies.

She underlined it twice.

Chapter 11 — The Long Walk Audit

One season later, by charter, the first annual Long Walk Audit began.

For twelve hours, mixed teams of residents, apprentices, officials, and one designated child-verifier would walk every critical route and compare map to lived conditions in real time.

Lina designed the audit packet: checklist, discrepancy symbols, witness boxes, repair urgency scale, and space for free notes because sometimes the most important detail did not fit a category.

At dawn bells, teams fanned out.

Lina led Route Cluster C with Mariam, Jun, two apprentice surveyors, and a nine-year-old named Ilyas who carried pencils behind his ear and asked relentless questions.

"Why mark this stair as moderate risk, not high?"

"Because handrail is solid but tread is chipped," Lina answered. "Moderate now, high if left."

"Why is uncertainty allowed on official maps?"

"Because pretending certainty where none exists is how harm starts."

Ilyas nodded as if filing that sentence for future use.

Midday brought a test. A courier reported that the old Glassbind evacuation corridor had fresh boards and looked reopened, though no completion notice had been filed. One apprentice suggested marking it clear based on appearance.

Lina shook her head. "No paperwork, no structural sign-off, no clear status."

They tested support beams. Two sagged under partial load.

Still unsafe.

She marked avoid and attached urgent repair order. The apprentice flushed, then thanked her for insisting.

By sunset, hundreds of notes returned to the Rotunda. Volunteers entered corrections on public boards while stewards read high-risk items aloud so no one could claim they missed them.

Final tally: eighty-two routes confirmed, seventeen minor updates, six urgent repairs, zero critical mismatches.

For the first time in years, emergency planners slept before midnight.

At closing ceremony, Councilor Yara handed Lina the renewal ballot results.

Independent Verifier, public approval: 94%.

Lina blinked hard, suddenly shy in front of applause.

"Can I nominate someone younger next year?" she asked.

Yara smiled. "You can mentor them."

Morrow landed on Ilyas's pencil and glowed.

The boy grinned. "Does that mean maybe me?"

Lina crouched to meet his eyes. "It means keep asking difficult, useful questions."

As lanterns dimmed, she looked across the hall at teams of adults and children packing maps side by side.

Power had not disappeared. But it had more windows now.

In labyrinth work, windows mattered.

Chapter 12 — Lines That Keep Their Word

In licensed classics, endings are less like doors shutting and more like lanterns being trimmed for the next reader.

By winter's first frost, the city had changed its habits.

Route corrections posted publicly each week. District names required resident consent to alter. Emergency maps carried uncertainty labels where needed. The child-verifier seat rotated yearly, chosen by open nomination and practical testing, not family status.

Starwell Annex appeared on every school atlas. Children there no longer said, "We are near somewhere else." They said, correctly, "We live in Starwell."

Master Pell's trial concluded with restitution orders, not only punishment. Records had to be repaired, services restored, and training rewritten around the old oath Lina had recovered. In classes across the Hall, apprentices now recited:

I refuse the comfort of useful lies.

Lina still worked at The Folded Horizon, sharpening pencils, measuring ribbon distances, and teaching younger kids how to sketch a room with exits marked first.

Morrow stayed, mostly.

Some nights the moth vanished into upper stacks and returned smelling faintly of old glue and moonlight, as if patrolling lies before they spread. Lina never caged it, never ordered it. Truth did not belong to one desk.

On the anniversary of the storm atlas, the city held a Map Festival in the Rotunda. There were workshops on tactile mapping, songs about bridges, and a contest for most useful hand-drawn neighborhood guide. Ilyas won with a map that included safe shortcuts, fruit stalls, and "best place to hear rain" under a copper awning.

At dusk Lina stood beneath the constellation ceiling with Nani, Mariam, Alma, Jun, and dozens of neighbors. She unveiled a new civic chart titled **LINES THAT KEEP THEIR WORD**.

It was not flawless. It had amber uncertainty marks and red pending threads in two corners.

People cheered anyway, because honest incompleteness was better than polished deceit.

Morrow flew up to the chart's compass rose and settled there, wings glowing warm gold.

Lina spoke into the hush:

"A map is a promise between people who make it and people who trust it. If the promise breaks, we repair it in public. If lines go wrong, we walk them together until they are right. That's how we stay findable to one another."

The crowd answered with the Rotunda response, old as ladders:

"So marked."

Then the bells rang night-mail across the stacks, and families folded the festival maps under their arms to take home.

Close the book now, if you like. Then look at the nearest route you rely on every day. Ask who checked it last, and for whom.

That question is how labyrinths stay kind.

THE END